

GA.3 Inspection Sequence

The inspection ladder for a Georgia dwelling, the two energy-test gates, what changes in a county that inspects nothing — and a log to record every result as you go.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. In Georgia the state minimum codes bind statewide, but permits and inspections are a local option — each county or city decides its own forms, fees, and enforcement, and some enforce nothing at all. Confirm every item with the office that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Georgia deletes the IRC's administration chapter, so your county's required-inspection list governs — get it in writing and staple it here.

WHY THERE IS NO STATEWIDE INSPECTION LIST

The 2026 Georgia Amendments to the 2024 IRC do something structural: *"Delete Chapter 1 'Scope and Administration' without substitution. Chapter 1 to remain in the Code as a reference and guide for local governments to use in the development of their own Administrative Procedures."* Permit administration, inspection scheduling, and certificate-of-occupancy issuance are therefore governed by **each local government's own administrative ordinance** — the IRC's inspection section (R109) survives only as a model.

Pair that with § 8-2-26(a)(4) — permits and inspections are a power a county **may** exercise — and the practical rule follows: the sequence below is the shape nearly every enforcing Georgia jurisdiction uses, but the binding list is the one your county hands you with the permit. Ask for it by name: "your required inspections list for a new single-family dwelling."

2026 Georgia Amendments to the 2024 IRC (DCA packet, read directly); O.C.G.A. § 8-2-26(a)(4). Verified August 2026.

THE MODEL SEQUENCE — WHAT IS TYPICALLY COMPLETE BEFORE EACH CALL

A model, not a statute — built on IRC § R109 as the guide Georgia kept it for, and on universal Georgia practice. Note the trade inspections: because Georgia deletes the IRC's plumbing, electrical, and energy parts, trade work is inspected against the **state IPC, the 2023 NEC, and the IMC/IFGC** — commonly as separate trade inspections, not one bundled visit.

Model Georgia residential inspection ladder (confirm against your county's list)

Inspection	What is typically complete / what is looked at
1. Footing / foundation	Trenches excavated, forms and reinforcing in place — before any concrete is placed. On a septic lot, the health-department construction permit must already be in hand before this stage of lot development (GA.2, section C).

Model Georgia residential inspection ladder (confirm against your county's list)

Inspection	What is typically complete / what is looked at
2. Under-slab plumbing	Everything the slab will conceal — under-slab plumbing, sleeves, vapor barrier, fill — complete and visible before the pour.
3. Rough plumbing	All plumbing that walls and ceilings will hide, in place and under test — inspected to the state IPC.
4. Rough electrical	All wiring, boxes, and service that will be concealed — inspected to the 2023 NEC.
5. Rough mechanical / gas	Ductwork, equipment connections, vents, and gas piping that will be concealed — inspected to the IMC and IFGC. If you will claim the duct-test exception, the ducts must sit entirely inside the thermal envelope — make that visible now.
6. Framing	Roof, wall, ceiling, and floor framing complete with blocking, bracing, and firestopping; rough-ins approved; penetrations flashed. Usually called after the trades pass.
7. Insulation	Insulation and air-sealing in place — before wall or ceiling coverings. Your blower-door number is being decided here.
8. Energy testing (DET)	Duct leakage test at rough-in or post-construction (unless excepted); blower door before final. Both by a certified DET verifier, both reported in writing — see the gate below.
9. Trade finals	Plumbing, electrical, and mechanical each complete and working.
10. Building final / CO	Everything done, site graded, septic final approval issued. The certificate of occupancy follows under your county's own administrative procedures.

Your county's actual list — copy it from the permit card or the department's handout, including anything it adds (site, erosion, temporary power) or bundles:

County-required inspections not shown above

Inspection	When it is called

Model sequence: IRC § R109 as guide plus universal Georgia practice — printed as a model because the 2026 Georgia Amendments delete IRC Chapter 1 and no statewide list exists. Trade codes: 2026 GA Amendments (IRC Parts IV, VII, VIII deleted). Verified August 2026.

THE ENERGY TESTS ARE GATES, NOT SUGGESTIONS

The DET reports are part of passing final

The blower-door rule does not stop at the number: *"A written report of the results of the test shall be signed by the party conducting the test and provided to the code official"* (GA IECC § R402.4.1.2) — and the test must come back **under 5 ACH50**, conducted by a certified DET verifier. The duct test (§ R403.3.3) runs at rough-in or post-construction, at **6 cfm25 per 100 sq ft** or better, unless ducts and air handlers sit entirely inside the envelope. In an enforcing county, no report means no final. Exactly when the CO issues is your county's administrative call — but book the verifier before drywall, not the week you want to move in.

GA amendments to the 2015 IECC, § R402.4.1.2 and §§ R403.3.3–.3.4 (DCA amendment PDFs, read directly). CO timing is local — Chapter 1 deleted. Verified August 2026.

THE SEPTIC FINAL — DO NOT BACKFILL

The county health department has its own final, and it comes before the trench is closed: *"No person may backfill or use an on-site sewage management system until a final inspection has been made by the County Board of Health"* and written approval issued (DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(4)). And the approval is not permanent armor: later site changes that adversely affect the system — regrading, driveways, additions over the drainfield — render it void (Rule -.03(4)(b)). Your building final and CO will wait on this in any county that checks.

DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(4), (4)(b) — official DPH rules PDF, read directly. Verified August 2026.

IF YOUR COUNTY INSPECTS NOTHING

Some Georgia counties run no building department and call no inspections. Your legal duty does not shrink: the eight state minimum codes apply statewide with no local adoption (§ 8-2-25(a)), and your own exemption is conditioned on the work conforming to them (§ 43-41-17(h)). What disappears is the free referee — so build your own verification:

- **Your lender and insurer will check anyway.** Construction loans draw against progress inspections, and insurers and future buyers' lenders ask for evidence the house met code. That is practical reality, not statute — but it is the enforcement you will actually feel.
- **Hire the inspection you were not given.** Georgia law contemplates private professional providers for plan review and inspection (§ 8-2-26(g)); even outside that mechanism, a private inspector working the ladder above at the same hold points is cheap against the cost of concealed defects.
- **The DET tests still happen.** The energy code and its testing rules are among the statewide-mandatory eight. Keep both signed reports even with no code official asking — they are the proof that outlives you selling the house.
- **The septic track never goes away.** County health departments permit and finally inspect septic in every county — that gate is DPH rule, not local option.

O.C.G.A. § 8-2-25(a); § 43-41-17(h); § 8-2-26(g) (procedural terms not printed — read the subsection before invoking it); DPH Rule 511-3-1. Lender and insurer practice is guidance, not law. Verified August 2026.

WHO ACTUALLY INSPECTS — AND WHAT A RE-CALL COSTS

The state trade boards license electricians, plumbers, and conditioned-air contractors — **they do not inspect houses**. Trade work is checked by your local inspector (or a private professional provider), against the state trade codes. Reinspection fees, re-call windows, and scheduling are per-jurisdiction — ask at your first inspection so your third holds no surprises:

How to schedule (portal/phone): _____ Notice required: _____

Reinspection fee: _____ Re-call wait: _____ Cutoff time: _____

THE CERTIFICATE AT THE END — AND WHY YOU KEEP IT

With IRC Chapter 1 deleted, when and how the certificate of occupancy issues is set by your county's administrative procedures — including whether you may occupy anything before it. Get that answer locally. Then file the CO somewhere permanent, twice over: it closes your permit file, and under § 43-41-17(h) it is the **start of the 24-month clock** that decides whether a future sale of this house poisons your next owner-built project. The date on this piece of paper is the one that counts.

CO administration local per the Chapter 1 deletion (2026 GA Amendments); 24-month clock from the CO date — O.C.G.A. § 43-41-17(h). Verified August 2026.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory. In a lightly-enforced county this log and your photos may be the only inspection record the house ever has — which makes it more valuable, not less.

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Footing / foundation					
Under-slab plumbing					
Rough plumbing					
Rough electrical					
Rough mechanical / gas					
Framing					

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Insulation					
Duct leakage test (DET)					
Blower door test (DET)					
Septic final					
Final — plumbing					
Final — electrical					
Final — mechanical					
Final — building					

Certificate of occupancy issued: _____ Number: _____

Sources (verified August 2026). IRC Chapter 1 deleted without substitution, kept only as a guide for local administrative procedures — 2026 Georgia Amendments to the 2024 IRC (DCA packet, read directly). Permits and inspections as a local power — O.C.G.A. § 8-2-26(a)(4); the eight mandatory codes statewide — § 8-2-25(a); owner-builder duty to conform — § 43-41-17(h); private professional providers — § 8-2-26(g). Blower-door test, DET verifier, and the signed report to the code official — GA IECC § R402.4.1.2; duct test and its inside-the-envelope exception — §§ R403.3.3–.3.4. Septic final inspection before backfill or use; approval voided by adverse site changes — DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(4), (4)(b). The ladder itself is a model (IRC § R109 as guide plus universal Georgia practice) — your county's list governs.